is a major gateway to the east and south. Apart from the important state-owned Visakhapatnam port and the private Gangavaram port (the deepest in the country), shipbuilding, steel, petrochemicals and pharmaceuticals are already contributing to its industrial growth. These have resulted from the state's significant investment in infrastructure development.

The presence of a highly skilled workforce, in what has evolved from a university town, has attracted many firms—over 1,500 IT and IT-enabled Services (ITeS) companies operate in the city. The sector contributes to about 7. 7 per cent of the state's GDP and is poised to reach 10 per cent by 2025. Andhra is negotiating with Singapore-based ST Telemedia to establish another data centre in Visakhapatnam before the year-end. The state-of-the-art Information Technology Tower at Hill No. 3 in the Rushikonda IT Park spread over 200,000 sq. ft is another draw. The state aims to give the IT sector a push by developing an ecosystem along the sea where offices for IT and ITeS firms will come up with a 'sea view'—a novel 'Beach IT' concept—on the lines of the Virginia Beach in the US. Beaches, cultural and historical landmarks and natural parks have also helped boost the city's economy through tourism.

"Our perspective plan is for a world-class metropolis with sustainable development and inclusive growth," says Gudivada Amarnath, the state's industries and IT minister. "We have identified six strategic goals—enhance economic competitiveness, promote balanced regional development, improve urban living, ensure environmental sustainability, strengthen social equity and inclusion, and foster good governance." The Global Investors Summit (GIS) held in Visakhapatnam in March is expected to lead to a flow of funds. "We are extending a special package of incentives to those companies that signed MoUs during the GIS and go for early ground-breaking within six months by September," says Amarnath.

The Raipur-Visakhapatnam economic corridor—a six-lane, 464-km-long access-controlled greenfield expressway—that will connect the Chhattisgarh capital with the coastal city via Odisha will be ready by 2025. It will reduce travel time between the two cities from 14 to about seven hours—improving the efficiency of freight movement and boosting exports. The corridor will also lead to easy connectivity of Vizag with other cities and markets in central and east-central India.

Factoring in the prospects, the Draft Master Plan 2041 has proposed a 1,627 sq. km area, or about 33 per cent of the VMRDA area, for urban development, covering 6.72 million people. "Vizag has risen. All it needs is for the government to listen to the voices of the business community and find ways to out-

CAPITAL MOVES

Andhra Pradesh CM Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy feels three capitals as growth nodes can accelerate prosperity



THE TRI-CAPITAL PLAN

- Visakhapatnam will be the state's executive capital
- Amaravati will continue as the legislative capital
- Kurnool–Andhra's erstwhile capital–will be the judicial capital after transfer of the High Court

LEGAL HURDLES

- The plan first mooted in Dec. 2019, along the lines of South Africa, faces legal hurdles
- The Supreme Court will decide the state's legislative competence to decide on its capitals
- Per the Andhra government's petition, depriving a state reorganised by a central legislation the power to reorganise its capital goes against the federal structure

FOR AND AGAINST

- Critics call the plan a waste of public funds
- The pro lobby stresses the merits of decentralisation. Eight states have the seat of administration and high courts in different cities
- Some complain Vizag is located at one end of the state. But so is Chennai in Tamil Nadu and Thiruvananthapuram in Kerala, and Mumbai in Maharashtra and Kolkata in West Bengal